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Title: Bridging IT Auditors and AI Auditing: Understanding Pathways to Effective IT Audits of AI-Driven Processes

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Summary:

This exploratory study examines how IT auditors can effectively evaluate AI-driven processes in accounting and business operations, addressing the challenges posed by AI's opaque decision-making logic compared to traditional IT systems. Through a survey of 89 experienced IT auditors, the authors identify and rank essential auditability measures and competencies needed for successful audits. Key findings reveal that top auditability measures include maintaining detailed logs, adhering to auditing standards, and implementing robust data governance processes, with AI-specific additions like model explainability and bias detection becoming crucial. Traditional IT audit measures, such as access controls and system integrity checks, remain relevant but must be supplemented to handle AI's unique risks, including ethical concerns like bias, accountability, and data privacy. The paper highlights that while AI enhances efficiency in tasks like bookkeeping and audits, it introduces vulnerabilities that IT auditors must mitigate to ensure reliable financial reporting and operational security.

The methodology involves a structured survey distributed via Qualtrics, drawing respondents from professional networks like ISACA, with analysis using descriptive statistics and ranking methods to prioritize factors. Results show practitioners prioritizing technical skills, such as AI knowledge and data analytics proficiency, over ethical or model-specific competencies, indicating a gap in holistic auditor readiness. For instance, competencies like evaluating AI model performance and understanding algorithmic fairness are deemed important but less emphasized than core IT skills. The study also notes the role of frameworks like COSO and COBIT in guiding AI audits, emphasizing the need for interdisciplinary collaboration to bridge traditional IT auditing with AI-specific requirements.

In conclusion, the authors advocate for updated training programs to equip IT auditors with AI expertise, suggesting that enhanced auditability measures can improve assurance in AI-driven processes. This research contributes foundational insights for designing AI audit tools and curricula, helping organizations manage risks while leveraging AI's benefits. It calls for future studies to validate these findings across diverse contexts and develop standardized AI audit protocols, positioning IT auditors as key players in safeguarding ethical AI integration in accounting.